

The Naqsh-e Jahan Square. Picture by Arad Mojtahedi

The Naqsh-e Jahan Square is a useful comparison to see the elements that are shared with the Taj Mahal. Like the Taj Mahal, the Square is a complex of buildings rather than a single structure, bounded by a rectilinear design where visitors pass through a central garden area while observing the buildings from a distance. The focus is upon the grand ceremonial gateways and the onion domes of the mosques, though in Isfahan, there is considerably more color in the buildings, unlike the uniform white marble of the Taj[19].

While Mumtaz Mahal was not a holy woman, she was (like most Persians) a Shi'a Muslim, and Shi'as have always had a deep reverence for women in the Qur'an, like Fatima Zahra (the Prophet's only daughter) and Zaynab bint Ali (the Prophet's granddaughter). They also have a tradition of constructing grand shrines over the sites of their tombs. While far simpler in style than the Taj Mahal, the Mosque over the tomb of Zaynab in Damascus (Sayyidah Zaynab Mosque) is one such tomb, and it has a broad paved courtyard with a single grand entrance, a minaret, and an onion dome behind it. Grander still is the tomb to a more distant female relation to the Prophet: Fatema Mæ'sume, the sister of the Eighth Imam. In the Persian holy city of Qom, it has more